Aquifer Open Bible Dictionary

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Z

Zaanaim

Zaanaim is the King James Version spelling of Zaanannim in Judges 4:11.

See Zaanannim.

Zaanan

Village mentioned in Micah's lament over Jerusalem (Mi 1:11). Zaanan is probably a play on the Hebrew word yatsa', "to come forth." The village was in the Shephelah; it is probably the same place as Zenan.

See also Zenan.

Zaanannim

One of the markers of the border of Naphtali listed between Heleph and Adami-nekeb (Jos 19:33). Judges 4:11 puts it near Kedesh. There Sisera took refuge in the tent of Heber the Kenite and was killed by Jael (vv 11–21). While the precise location is not known, it was west of Lake el-Huleh (modern Merom) in a region that was probably marshy in ancient times. Though the kjv translates the text as "plain of Zaanaim," it is more likely "Oak of Zaanannim" (rsv, niv, nlt). Since many terebinth trees are located in the region, the text is probably referring to a terebinth set aside as a sacred tree.

Zaavan

Zaavan was the second son of Ezer, a Horite clan leader (Genesis 36:27; 1 Chronicles 1:42).

Zabad

1. Son of Nathan (1 Chr 2:36) and a descendant of Ahlai the daughter of Sheshan (vv 30, 34–36).
2. Tahath's son and the father of Shuthelah from Ephraim's tribe (1 Chr 7:21).
3. One of David's mighty men, listed as a son of Ahlai (1 Chr 11:41); he is perhaps the same as #1 above.
4. One of the assassins of King Joash, listed as the son of Shimeath the Ammonitess (2 Chr 24:26). He is identical to Jozacar (alternately "Jozabad") in 2 Kings 12:21. Zabad was a palace official who was likely the agent of a powerful conspiracy against Joash.

See also Jozacar, Jozachar.

5–7. Three priests variously descended from Zattu, Hashum, and Nebo, who renounced their foreign wives at Ezra's request during the postexilic period (Ezr 10:27, 33, 43).

Zabbai

1. Bebai's son and one of the priests who divorced his foreign wife at Ezra's command (Ezr 10:28).
2. Father of Baruch. Baruch repaired a section of the Jerusalem wall during Nehemiah's day (Neh 3:20).

Zabbud

Zabbud is the King James Version form of Zaccur, Bigvai's descendant, in Ezra 8:14.

See Zaccur #5.

Zabdi

1. Zerah's descendant from the tribe of Judah (Joshua 7:1). Achan was a Zerahite of the family of Zabdi (Joshua 7:17–18). He is also called Zimri (1 Chronicles 2:6).
2. Shimei's son and a descendant of Ehud from the tribe of Benjamin (1 Chronicles 8:19).
3. David's officer in charge of the grapes of the vineyards for the wine cellars (1 Chronicles 27:27). He is called a Shiphmite, which likely means that he was a native of Shepham.
4. One of the temple musicians of the order of Asaph (Nehemiah 11:17). He is also called Zicri (1 Chronicles 9:15).

Zabdiel

1. Father of Jashobeam, the commander of the first division of David's army (1 Chr 27:2).
2. Priest and overseer of 128 "mighty men of valor" (rsv, Neh 11:14). The notation that he was a "son of Haggedolim" might indicate that he was a "son of the mighty men."
3. Arab who beheaded Alexander (Balas) Epiphanes and sent the head to Ptolemy (1 Macc 11:17).

Zabud

A priest in the court of King Solomon and the "adviser to the king" (1 Kings 4:5). The phrase "adviser to the king" may be an official title. Hushai the Archite had a similar title ("friend") in the court of King David (2 Samuel 15:37; 16:16).

Zabulon

The King James Version spelling of Zebulun in Matthew 4:13–15 and Revelation 7:8.

See Zebulun, Tribe of.

Zaccai

Zaccai was the ancestor of a family who returned with Zerubbabel to Judah after the exile in Babylon (Ezra 2:9; Nehemiah 7:14).

Zacchaeus

Zacchaeus was a Jewish tax collector who worked for the Romans in the city of Jericho. He became very wealthy by collecting taxes, often by dishonest means. He likely got this job either by paying for the right to collect taxes in that area or by working for another wealthy official. Jericho was an important city for trade because it was on a major road between Jerusalem and the lands east of the Jordan River.

The Gospel of Luke tells the story of how Zacchaeus met Jesus(Luke 19:2–8). Zacchaeus wanted to see Jesus, but he was too short to see over the crowd. So he climbed a sycamore tree to watch Jesus pass by. Jesus surprised him by stopping under the tree. Jesus called to Zacchaeus and said he wanted to stay at his house that night. This changed Zacchaeus's life. He turned away from his dishonest ways and followed Jesus. He promised to pay back four times as much to anyone he had cheated. He also promised to give money to poor people. According to Clement of Alexandria, Zacchaeus later became a church leader in the city of Caesarea (Homily 3.63).

Zacchur

Zacchur is the King James Version spelling of Zaccur, Hammuel's son, in 1 Chronicles 4:26.

See Zaccur #2.

Zaccur

1. A Reubenite and father of Shammua. Shammua was one of the 12 spies who explored Canaan (Numbers 13:4).
2. A Simeonite who was the son of Hammuel and the father of Shimei (1 Chronicles 4:26).
3. One of the descendants of Merari in the record of the divisions of the priests (1 Chronicles 24:27).
4. One of the sons of Asaph who had responsibilities for service in the temple(1 Chronicles 25:2). David assigned Zaccur and his sons and brothers the third lot among the various duties for the temple musicians (1 Chronicles 25:10). Descendants of Zaccur were present at the dedication of the city wall following the exile (Nehemiah 12:35).
5. One of the descendants of Bigvai who returned to Jerusalem with Ezra (Ezra 8:14).
6. A son of Imri who worked on repairing the wall of Jerusalem in the area of the Sheep Gate (Nehemiah 3:2).
7. One of the Levites who signed the covenant of Nehemiah to obey the law of God (Nehemiah 10:12).
8. A son of Mattaniah and father of Hanan. Hanan was the assistant to the storehouse treasurers during the time of Nehemiah (Nehemiah 13:13). Some have suggested that he is the same person as #7 above.

Zachariah

1. The King James Version spelling of Zechariah, king of Israel, in 2 Kings 14:29 and 15:8, 11.

See Zechariah (Person) #1.

1. The King James Version spelling of Zechariah, the father of King Hezekiah's mother, in 2 Kings 18:2.

See Zechariah (Person) #2.

Zacharias

1. The King James Version spelling of Zechariah, Jehoiada's son, in Matthew 23:35 and Luke 11:51.

See Zechariah (Person) #14.

1. The King James Version spelling of Zechariah, John the Baptist's father, in Luke 1:5–67.

See Zechariah (Person) #31.

1. The King James Version spelling of Zechariah, a proposed name for John the Baptist, in Luke 1:59.

See John the Baptist; Zechariah (Person) #32.

Zacher

Zacher is the King James Version form of Zechariah, or Zeker, in 1 Chronicles 8:31.

See Zechariah (Person) #5.

Zadok

Common OT name meaning "righteous one."

1. David's priest, probably the most famous and influential of Israel's high priests apart from Aaron. He first appeared at the time of Absalom's revolt, when he and his fellow priest Abiathar showed their loyalty to David by coming to him with the ark, fully prepared to share his exile (2 Sm 15:24–29). David refused their offer and sent them back to Jerusalem to act in his interests.

In 2 Samuel 8:17, Zadok is listed as the son of Ahitub, who is noted in 1 Samuel 14:3 as the grandson of Eli. In the genealogies of Chronicles, Zadok's descent through Ahitub is traced back to Eleazar, the eldest son of Aaron (1 Chr 6:1–8, 50–53; Ezr 7:2–5), but with no reference to Eli. A slight problem emerges in that Zadok replaces the banished Abiathar, a descendant of Eli. This is regarded as the fulfillment of an earlier prophecy that the tenure of the high priestly office by Eli's family would be broken in favor of a different branch of Aaron's family (1 Sm 2:30–36; 1 Kgs 2:26–27).

In both summaries of David's court officials (2 Sm 8:17; 20:25), Zadok is listed as one of David's two principal priests, an office held throughout the latter part of David's reign. When David was near death, a power struggle over the throne was precipitated by Adonijah, David's oldest surviving son. With the support of Joab, the commander of the army, and the priest Abiathar, David's long-standing friend, Adonijah declared himself king (1 Kgs 1:5–10). Nathan the prophet promptly intervened with Bathsheba as Solomon's advocate. Zadok and Benaiah, the captain of the mercenary troops, supported Solomon. Adonijah's cause was hopeless once David had indicated his approval of Nathan's plans. Consequently, the discredited Abiathar was banished (2:26–27), leaving the loyal Zadok as Solomon's chief priest (2:35; 4:4).

In the centuries that followed, the descendants of Zadok preserved this dominance, and as Jerusalem's prestige increased, so did their status. Azariah, the chief priest in Hezekiah's reign, was a Zadokite (2 Chr 31:10). Ezekiel restricted the main priestly functions to the "sons of Zadok," demoting the Levites generally to the rank of "temple caretakers" because of their apostasy during the monarchy (Ez 44:10–16). When the Jews came under Seleucid domination in the early second century BC, the high priesthood, regarded as a political appointment, was taken away from the Zadokites. Conservative elements, however, like the Qumran covenanters, continued to look for its restoration.

See also David; Israel, History of.

2. Father-in-law of Uzziah and grandfather of Jotham, kings of Judah (2 Kgs 15:32–33; 2 Chr 27:1).
3. Descendant of Zadok, David's priest (1 Chr 6:12; 9:11; Neh 11:11).
4. Young man of exceptional courage, the leader of a contingent that joined David at Hebron against Saul (1 Chr 12:28).
5. Son of Baana, who helped to repair the wall of Jerusalem in Nehemiah's time (Neh 3:4).
6. Son of Immer, who also shared in Nehemiah's rebuilding operations (Neh 3:29).
7. Signatory to Nehemiah's covenant (Neh 10:21) and perhaps identifiable with #5 or #6 above.
8. One of three treasurers appointed by Nehemiah during his second term of office, called the scribe (Neh 13:13).
9. Ancestor of Christ (Mt 1:14). See Genealogy of Jesus Christ.

Zaham

Zaham was one of Rehoboam's sons with his wife Mahalath (2 Chronicles 11:19).

Zair

Place where Joram attacked and defeated the Edomites (2 Kgs 8:21). In the parallel passage of 2 Chronicles 21:9, the phrase "to Zair" is replaced by the phrase "with his commanders" (the Hebrew words are similar). Many have therefore suggested that a copyist revision appeared in 2 Chronicles because the location of Zair was unknown. Others have suggested that Zair should be identified with Zoar on the southeast end of the Dead Sea, or with Seir in Edom. In any case, it was located in Transjordan on a principal road to Edom.

Zalaph

Zalaph was the father of Hanun. Hanun repaired a section of the Jerusalem wall during the time of Nehemiah (Nehemiah 3:30).

Zalmon (Person)

One of the mighty men of King David (2 Samuel 23:28). Another name for him is "Ilai the Ahohite" (1 Chronicles 11:29).

Zalmon (Place)

Mountain from which Abimelech took brush to burn down the tower of Shechem (Jgs 9:48). Since the mountain obviously was close to Shechem, it tentatively has been identified with es-Sulemiyeh (the modern name for the southeastern portion of Mt Ebal) or one of its surrounding hills. Zalmon is also mentioned in connection with the defeat of Israel's enemies in Psalm 68:14. Because of the mention of snowfall and the "mighty mountain of Bashan" in the following verse, the Septuagint and some commenta-

tors consider this Zalmon to be Mt Hermon in Lebanon. However, seasonal snowfalls also occur in the region of Mt Ebal.

Zalmonah

A place where the Israelites camped during their journey. They came to this place after they left Mount Hor (Numbers 33:41–42). The name Zalmonah suggests that it might have been a dark or shady valley. This valley probably led up to the high flat land of Edom.

Zalmunna

Zalmunna was a Midianite king in the Old Testament. He ruled together with another king named Zebah. Both men fought against Israel during the time of the judges.

See Zebah and Zalmunna.

Zamzummim, Zamzummites

The Ammonite name for the Rephaim. Deuteronomy 2:20 describes them as "a people great and many, as tall as the Anakites." The Zamzummites were forced out of their land by the Ammonites, just as the Horites were forced out by the Edomites and the Avvim by the Caphtorim. The comparison with the Anakim, the Rephaim, and the Emim shows that the Zamzummites were a race of giants. They lived in Transjordan (a region east of the Jordan River). Although their exact origin is unknown, they probably lived in the area near Rabbath-ammon.

See also Giants; Rephaim.

Zanoah (Person)

Descendant of Caleb from Judah's tribe (1 Chr 4:18). Zanoah was the son of Jekuthiel and, depending on the translation of the Hebrew text, may have been related to Bithiah, the daughter of Pharaoh. Some have interpreted the text as indicating that Jekuthiel was the founder or principal settler of the city named Zanoah. In any case, Zanoah's descendants may well have been connected with the city of that name.

Zanoah (Place)

1. One of the cities "in the lowland" that was part of Judah's inheritance (Jos 15:34). The inhabitants of Zanoah worked with Hanun to rebuild the Valley Gate as well as about 1,500 feet (457.2 meters) of the city wall during the restoration of Jerusalem (Neh 3:13; 11:30). The city is probably identifiable with Zanu'a, which is located approximately 10 miles (16.1 kilometers) west of Jerusalem.
2. One of the cities in the Judean highlands south of Hebron that was part of Judah's inheritance (Jos 15:56). It was probably inhabited by the descendants of Zanoah, Jekuthiel's son.

Zaphenath-Paneah

Name given to Joseph by Pharaoh when Joseph assumed his governmental responsibilities in Egypt (Gn 41:45). The name most likely means "says the god, he will live." See Joseph #1.

Zaphon

Town located east of the Jordan River (Jos 13:27) and included as part of the inheritance of Gad's tribe (v 24). Egyptian records (13th century BC) refer to a town known as Dapuna, while an Amarna text spells the name Sapuna.

Zara, Zarah

The King James Version alternate forms of Zerah, Judah's son, in Genesis 38:30, 46:12, and Matthew 1:3.

See Zerah #2.

Zareah, Zareathite

Zareah and Zareathite are the King James Version spellings of Zorah and Zorathite in Nehemiah 11:29 and 1 Chronicles 2:53, respectively.

See Zorah, Zorathite.

Zared

The King James Version spelling for the valley of Zered in Numbers 21:12.

See Zered.

Zarephath

A village where the woman who provided food and lodging for Elijah lived (1 Kings 17:9–10; Luke 4:26). Obadiah later prophesied that the Israelite exiles of Halah would "possess the land of the Canaanites as far as Zarephath" (Obadiah 1:20). Zarephath was under the control of Sidon at the time Elijah visited, thus serving as a safe haven from King Ahab of Israel. Zarephath is likely the modern Surafend, where a chapel marks the traditional site for the widow's house.

Zarethan

City or region near the Jordan River north of Jericho. It is first mentioned in connection with the "cutting off" of the waters of the Jordan that occurred at Adam, "the city that is beside Zarethan" (Jos 3:16). Its loca-

tion is more precisely defined in the list of Solomon's administrative districts as being in the vicinity of Beth-shan below Jezreel (1 Kgs 4:12). Bronze utensils for Solomon's temple were cast near there (7:46; 2 Chr 4:17, "Zeredah").

Zareth-shahar

Zareth-shahar is the King James Version spelling of Zereth-shahar, a Reubenite city, in Joshua 13:19.

See Zereth-shahar.

Zarhite

1. The King James Version spelling of Zerahite, which refers to a person who is a descendant of Zerah's family in the tribe of Simeon (Numbers 26:13).

See Zerah #3.

1. The King James Version spelling of Zerahite, which refers to a person who is a descendant of Zerah's family in the tribe of Judah (Numbers 26:20).

See Zerah #2.

Zartanah, Zarthan

Zartanah and Zarthan are different spellings found in the King James Version of the Bible. Zartanah appears in 1 Kings 4:12, and Zarthan appears in 7:46. Both names refer to the place called Zarethan.

See Zarethan.

Zatthu

Zatthu is the King James Version spelling of Zattu in Nehemiah 10:14.

See Zattu #2.

Zattu

1. Clan chief with whom 945 people returned with Zerubbabel (Ezr 2:8; Neh 7:13 cites 845 returnees). Of the priests who renounced their foreign wives, six are listed as "sons" of Zattu (Ezr 10:27).
2. One of the chiefs of the people who signed Nehemiah's covenant (Neh 10:14); perhaps the same person as #1 above.

Zavan

Zavan is the King James Version spelling of Zaavan, Ezer's son, in 1 Chronicles 1:42.

See Zaavan.

Zaza

Zaza was Jonathan's son, in the family of Jerahmeel, a member of the tribe of Judah (1 Chronicles 2:33).

Zealot

A zealot is someone who is very passionate about a cause or belief.

Simon the Zealot

In the Bible, this term is used to describe Simon, one of the twelve closest followers of Jesus (Luke 6:15; Acts 1:13). This Simon is different from Simon Peter, who was also one of the twelve.

Matthew and Mark call Simon "the Cananaean" in the Greek text (the Berean Standard Bible translates it "Zealot" in Matthew 10:4; Mark 3:18). This title comes from an Aramaic word that means "a zealous person." The term describes someone who strongly supports or defends a cause. It comes from a root word that can mean "to burn with zeal or jealousy" or "to desire eagerly" (Exodus 34:14; 2 Maccabees 4:2).

Jesus himself showed zeal (strong enthusiasm) when he cleared the temple of people who were misusing it. The Bible says he had "zeal for God's house" (John 2:17).

In the early Christian church, some believers were zealous for spiritual gifts, good works, and following God's law (Acts 21:20; 1 Corinthians 14:12; Titus 2:14). Paul, before he became a follower of Jesus, was very zealous for the traditions of his ancestors and for God (Acts 22:3; Galatians 1:14).

Simon the Zealot was known for his strong religious enthusiasm. This is how people could tell him apart from Simon Peter and the other followers of Jesus.

How the Zealot Movement Began

By the time Luke wrote his Gospel, the title "Zealot" had come to mean something more specific. It referred to a group of people who were strongly against Roman rule over their land. This group had both religious and political goals.

This Zealot group may have started around AD 6, after the death of King Herod the Great. It was possibly founded by Judas the Galilean and Zadok the Pharisee. The Zealots were inspired by the Maccabees, who had fought against foreign rule many years earlier (1 Maccabees 2:15–28).

The Zealots were very devoted to following God's law (called the Torah). They believed that God was the only true king. They saw themselves as agents of God's judgment and salvation. They strongly opposed

anything they saw as going against God or cooperating with Rome. The Zealots thought that the Messiah (God's chosen leader) would become their leader.

Zealots in Jewish History and Their Fight Against Rome

As tensions grew between Rome and Judea (the Jewish homeland), the Zealots became more militant. They saw their fight as a holy war. While the Maccabees had fought to defend themselves, the Zealots became more aggressive.

Josephus, a Jewish historian, called them robbers and criminals (Antiquities 18.1.1–6; War 4.3.9), though he may have been biased against them. The Romans called them sicarii, which means "assassins." But their supporters would have called them patriotic fighters.

The Zealots played a big role in the revolt against Rome from AD 66 to 70. Their last stronghold was at a place called Masada. It fell to the Romans in AD 73, and the 960 Zealots there chose to die by suicide rather than be captured.

Simon the Zealot was probably part of this movement in its earlier days, around AD 30. It's less likely that other disciples like Judas Iscariot or the Sons of Thunder (the sons of Zebedee, James and John) were Zealots (Mark 3:17). Judas the Galilean and even Paul were thought by some to be Zealots (Acts 5:37–38; 21:38).

See also First Jewish Revolt; Judaism.

Zealot, Simon the

See Simon #5.

Zebadiah

1. One of the sons of Beriah from Benjamin's tribe (1 Chr 8:15).
2. One of the sons of Elpaal from Benjamin's tribe (1 Chr 8:17).
3. One of the sons of Jeroham of Gedor, who came to David's support at Ziklag (1 Chr 12:7).
4. Korahite Levite descended from Asaph, third of Meshelemiah's seven sons and a temple gatekeeper (1 Chr 26:2).
5. Son of Asahel, Joab's brother, who was the commander of the fourth division of David's army (1 Chr 27:7).
6. One of the Levites sent by Jehoshaphat into the cities of Judah to teach the law (2 Chr 17:8).
7. Ishmael's son and one of the leaders of the Levites whom Jehoshaphat appointed as governor of civil affairs for the house of Judah (2 Chr 19:11).
8. Michael's son from Shephatiah's house, who returned with Ezra to Jerusalem following the exile (Ezr 8:8).
9. One of the sons of Immer who renounced his foreign wife at Ezra's command (Ezr 10:20).

Zebah and Zalmunna

Two Midianite kings who slaughtered Gideon's brothers at Tabor. Gideon subsequently killed them in order to avenge his brothers' deaths (Jgs 8:18–21).

During Gideon's day, Midianite camel raiders annually made forays into Israelite territory at harvesttime, stealing crops and livestock (Jgs 6:3). So complete were their raids that nothing was left in Israel, including crops, sheep, oxen, or donkeys.

In this state of affairs God called Gideon to deliver Israel (Jgs 6:16). His well-known victory over Midian near Mt Moreh was an important step toward realization of this divine commission (7:1–23). In the operations following the battle, Ephraimite warriors captured and assassinated two Midianite leaders named Zeeb and Oreb (7:24–8:3).

Gideon determined to capture Zebah and Zalmunna, the kings of the Midianite forces. In tracking them down, he crossed the Jordan River and traveled more than 100 miles (160.9 kilometers) from the site of the original battle. Along the way, two successive towns, Succoth and Penuel, refused to help Gideon and his men, doubtless fearing reprisal from the Midianite raiders should Gideon fail to defeat them.

Gideon routed the remaining Midianite warriors and captured Zebah and Zalmunna (Jgs 8:12). Because Zebah and Zalmunna had killed his brothers, Gideon killed the two Midianite kings (vv 19–21). Psalm 83:11 indicates that Zebah, Zalmunna, and the Midianites were the enemies not merely of Israel but also of God.

Zebaim

Zebaim is the King James Version spelling of Pochereth-hazzebaim, a place mentioned in Ezra 2:57 and Nehemiah 7:59.

See Pochereth-Hazzebaim, Pochereth of Zebaim.

Zebedee

The father of the disciples James and John (Matthew 26:37; Mark 3:17; 10:35). Zebedee was a fisher and

may have been wealthy since he had servants and connections with the high priest (John 18:15). Although he personally appears only once in the narrative (Matthew 4:21; Mark 1:19–20), his wife, Salome, appears often as one of the believers who followed Christ.

Zebidah

The mother of Jehoiakim, who was a king of Judah. Zebidah was King Josiah's wife and the daughter of Pedaiah (2 Kings 23:36).

Zebina

Zebina was Nebo's son, who obeyed Ezra's command to divorce his non-Jewish wife after the exile in Babylon (Ezra 10:43).

Zeboiim

One of the "cities of the plain" that was destroyed with Sodom and Gomorrah (Dt 29:23; Hos 11:8). Zeboiim is first mentioned, with Sodom, Gomorrah, and Admah, as one of the Canaanite cities in the "table of nations" in Genesis 10:19. It later appears confederated with the same states (including Zoar) in the battle against Amraphel king of Shinar, Arioch king of Ellasar, Kedorlaomer king of Elam, and Tidal king of Goiim (Gn 14:2, 8).

See also Cities of the Plain.

Zeboim

1. KJV spelling of Zeboiim in Genesis 10:19, Deuteronomy 29:23, and Hosea 11:8. See Zeboiim.
2. Valley where one of the raiding parties of the Philistines turned toward the border of the wilderness (1 Sm 13:18). It may be identified with Shuk ed-Dubba.
3. One of the villages outside of Jerusalem where the Benjaminites settled after the exile (Neh 11:34).

Zebudah

The King James Version's spelling of Zebidah in 2 Kings 23:36. Zebidah was the wife of King Josiah.

See Zebidah.

Zebul

Ruler of Shechem who served as an officer of Abimelech (Jgs 9:28–30). Zebul apparently obtained his position when Abimelech was crowned king at Shechem. When Gaal the son of Ebed incited the Shechemites to rebel against Abimelech, Zebul played an instrumental role in Abimelech's victory. After he goaded Gaal into attacking Abimelech outside of the city, Zebul shut Gaal out of the city, preventing retreat into its confines. It is difficult to determine Zebul's fate when Abimelech later attacked and destroyed the city, but it is possible that he too met a treacherous fate.

Zebulun (Person)

One of Jacob's 12 sons (Genesis 35:23; 1 Chronicles 2:1). He was the sixth and last son of Jacob and Leah. She named him Zebulun, meaning "abode, dwelling." She said, "This time my husband will honor me, because I have borne him six sons" (Genesis 30:20). Later, he settled his family in Egypt with Jacob and his brothers (Exodus 1:3).

Jacob prophesied that Zebulun's descendants would live on the coast, with their border touching Sidon (Genesis 49:13). Zebulun's tribe was between Asher's and Naphtali's tribes. Asher's was by the Mediterranean, and Naphtali's was by the Sea of Galilee. Despite this, Zebulun prospered in trade with the Canaanite coastal cities. Zebulun fathered three sons (Genesis 46:14) and founded one of Israel's 12 tribes (Numbers 1:30–31).

See also Zebulun, Tribe of.

Zebulun, Tribe of

A tribe descended from Zebulun, Jacob's tenth son and Leah's sixth (Genesis 30:19–20). Zebulun's tribe was split into three clans named after his sons: the Seredites, Elonites, and Jahleelites (Genesis 46:14; Numbers 26:27). During the census on the plains of Moab, the tribe had 60,500 men over 20 years old who were fit for military service (Numbers 26:26–27).

Land and Territory

Zebulun's land was in central Canaan and included the Jezreel Valley. However, the exact boundaries are hard to pinpoint because only the southeastern and eastern borders are mentioned in Joshua 19:10–16. The western border along the Mediterranean is not clearly defined. Moses's blessing suggests that Zebulun, with Issachar, would "feast on the abundance of the seas" (Deuteronomy 33:18–19). This implies access to the Mediterranean and its trade

Despite this, Zebulun's territory does not seem to touch the sea, which appears to contradict Genesis 49:13. However, Zebulun was in a good location along major trade routes to the sea. This allowed them to benefit from trade by sea, even if they were not directly on the coast. The land of Zebulun was good for growing crops and produced olive groves, vineyards,

and plentiful harvests. In 1 Chronicles 12:40, the tribe provided generous supplies for David.

Military Strength

Zebulun maintained a strong position among its neighbors. Unlike Asher and Naphtali, which lived among the Canaanites (Judges 1:32–33), Zebulun had fewer Canaanites in their area. During the period of the judges, Zebulun was very active. For instance, Zebulun and Naphtali soldiers were key in the victory at the battle of Kishon (Judges 4:6–10). The Song of Deborah praises Zebulun for risking their lives (Judges 5:18). According to Judges 6:35, the men of Zebulun fought bravely in Gideon's struggle with the Midianites on the plain of Jezreel. Judge Elon belonged to the tribe of Zebulun (Judges 12:11–12). Since Galilee was in the territory of Zebulun, Ibzan of Bethlehem was probably also from Zebulun (Joshua 19:15). Zebulun's fighting force was among the largest in David's western armies (1 Chronicles 12:33). This is another sign that Zebulun's tribe was both strong and important.

Zebulun in the New Testament

In the New Testament, Zebulun is mentioned twice. It is noted as a region where Jesus, described as a great light, appeared (Matthew 4:13–15). Zebulun is also listed among the 12 tribes in Revelation 7:8 after Issachar.

See also Zebulun (Person).

Zebulunite

Any descendant of Zebulun, son of the patriarch Jacob (Numbers 26:27; Judges 12:11–12).

See Zebulun, Tribe of.

Zechariah, Book of

Zechariah is the longest of the twelve books known as the Minor Prophets in the Old Testament. These books are called "minor" because they are shorter than the major prophetic books.

Zechariah can also be the most difficult to understand. One reason is that it contains many visions whose meanings need explanation. A vision is an experience in which God shows someone scenes or images that communicate a message. A vision may occur while the person is awake or asleep. Sometimes an angel explains a vision (Zechariah 1:9–10, 19–20; 4:1–6; 5:5–6). At other times, no angel explains it, even when its meaning is unclear. These difficult passages have led to many theories about when the book was written, who wrote it, whether its parts belong together, and what it means.

Zechariah is important for Christians because of its use in the New Testament. The Gospel accounts of the suffering and death of Jesus quote the final section of Zechariah (Zechariah 9–14) more often than any other section of the prophetic books. Zechariah also influenced the book of Revelation more than any other Old Testament book except Ezekiel.

Preview

- Who Wrote the Book of Zechariah?
- When Was the Book of Zechariah Written?
- What Is the Background of the Book of Zechariah?
- Why Was the Book of Zechariah Written?
- What Is the Book of Zechariah About?

Who Wrote the Book of Zechariah?

The name Zechariah likely means "the Lord remembers" or "the Lord is renowned." Zechariah is a common name in the Old Testament and New Testament. At least 30 different people in the Old Testament are named Zechariah. There is confusion about the prophet's father. In Zechariah 1:1 and 1:7, he is called "son of Berechiah, the son of Iddo," but in Ezra 5:1 and 6:14, he is called "son of Iddo." Another Zechariah from Isaiah's time had a father named Jeberechiah (Isaiah 8:2).

A different prophet named Zechariah, the son of Jehoiada the priest, lived earlier during King Joash's reign in Judah, from 835 to 796 BC. This prophet was stoned to death for saying the Lord had abandoned his people due to their sins (2 Chronicles 24:20–22). Jesus seemed to refer to this or a similar unrecorded event, but he calls the prophet the son of Berechiah, the last of the martyrs (people killed for their faith or message) among the prophets (Matthew 23:35).

However, Luke's account of Jesus's words about Zechariah (Luke 11:51) does not mention "the son of Berechiah." Some interpreters understand Jesus's words as referring to Zechariah son of Jehoiada. In the traditional Jewish ordering, Chronicles is the last book of the Hebrew Bible. On this interpretation, Abel and Zechariah represent the first and last recorded murders of righteous people in that arrangement. There is no evidence that the prophet from the book of Zechariah was martyred. Therefore, it is best to consider Berechiah as the father and Iddo as the grandfather of this prophet.

When Was the Book of Zechariah Written?

The first part of the book of Zechariah (Zechariah 1–8) is easy to date. The first date appears in the first verse: "the eighth month of the second year of Darius." This refers to Darius, king of Persia, who ruled from 521

to 486 BC. The eighth month of Darius's second year is October 520 BC. This date marks the first time the "word of the LORD" came to Zechariah.

The second date in Zechariah is in Zechariah 1:7: "On the twenty-fourth day of the eleventh month, the month of Shebat, in the second year of Darius." This date corresponds to February 15, 519 BC. The word of the Lord that came to Zechariah on this date includes the account of eight night visions and some messages from an angel who spoke with him. The third date in Zechariah is in Zechariah 7:1: "In the fourth year of King Darius… on the fourth day of the ninth month, the month of Chislev." This date is equivalent to December 7, 518 BC.

There are no dates in Zechariah 9–14. Zechariah's name is not mentioned, nor is Darius or any king. A time of peace and stability changes to war. The temple is standing (Zechariah 11:13; 14:20), and Greek soldiers seem to be present (9:13). Trying to assign specific dates to Zechariah 9–14 would only be a guess.

What Is the Background of the Book of Zechariah?

Nebuchadnezzar, the king of Babylon, destroyed the temple in Jerusalem in 586 BC. He attacked Jerusalem several times, taking many people to Babylon (see 2 Kings 24:1–17; Daniel 1:1). Jeremiah predicted twice that the captivity (the time when the people were held in Babylon) would last 70 years (Jeremiah 25:11; 29:10; see also Daniel 9:2). During Zechariah's time, the 70-year period since Jerusalem's fall was nearing its end (Zechariah 1:12; 7:5). It had been 66 years since Jerusalem fell when Zechariah received the first "word of the LORD" in the second year of Darius (520 BC). The Persian Empire conquered Babylon in 538 BC, and Cyrus, the first Persian king, allowed the Jewish exiles (people forced to live away from their homeland) to return to Jerusalem and rebuild the temple (2 Chronicles 36:23; Ezra 1:1–4).

The first group of Jewish captives returned to Jerusalem with Zerubbabel and Joshua the priest around 536 BC. Their main goal was to rebuild the temple (Ezra 1:3), but internal conflicts and opposition from the Samaritans delayed the rebuilding.

After Darius I became king of Persia in 521 BC, hope and excitement grew among the Jewish communities in Jerusalem and Babylon. Two prophets, possibly from the Babylonian exiles, Haggai and Zechariah, preached so effectively that work on the second temple began in 520 BC and finished in 516 BC (Ezra 5:1, 14–15; Haggai 1–2; Zechariah 1–8).

The book of Zechariah begins in the second year of Darius (520 BC). Some captives had returned to Jerusalem 16 years earlier, but they had not started rebuilding the temple. Zechariah's first message urged the people to repent (turn away from sin and return to God) and avoid repeating their ancestors' mistakes. Their ancestors' sins and refusal to repent led to exile and the temple's destruction (Zechariah 1:1–6). Then, Zechariah shares eight night visions (Zechariah 1:7–6:8) that promise the temple will be rebuilt by Zerubbabel (Zechariah 1:16; 4:9; 6:15).

Two verses in Zechariah highlight the challenges in Jerusalem before the temple's reconstruction: "This is what the LORD of Hosts says: 'Let your hands be strong, you who now hear these words spoken by the prophets who were present when the foundations were laid to rebuild the temple, the house of the LORD of Hosts. For before those days neither man nor beast received wages, nor was there safety from the enemy for anyone who came or went, for I had turned every man against his neighbor'" (Zechariah 8:9–10).

The first eight chapters of Zechariah focus on the social, political, and religious situations in Jerusalem from 520 to 518 BC. Starting with Zechariah 9, the historical context is unclear. Chapter 9 begins with a prophecy against Syria, including Damascus, Tyre, Sidon, and Philistia. These places will be conquered, purified, and become like a clan in Judah. There is a promise of a new king coming to Jerusalem triumphantly, yet humbly riding a donkey. His rule will be peaceful and worldwide.

The next prophecy talks about freeing captives, but it might not mean the Babylonian captives because it mentions the Greeks. Zechariah 9–12 mainly focuses on the future. Some scholars describe this part as apocalyptic literature, which uses visions and symbols to describe God's judgment and future rule. Nations attack Jerusalem and are defeated (Zechariah 12, 14). The temple is standing (Zechariah 11:13), but it does not seem very important in the new Jerusalem and the kingdom of God (Zechariah 14:6–9).

Why Was the Book of Zechariah Written?

The book aims to reassure and encourage. The Jewish community in 520 BC needed to know the temple would be rebuilt. Later, God's people needed to understand that God's kingdom would eventually come in full. The book of Zechariah has three main messages:

1. the need for repentance (Zechariah 1:1–5:11);
2. the eight night visions (Zechariah 1:7–6:8) showing that the temple would be rebuilt and God's glory would return to Jerusalem; and

3. the coming of God's kingdom (Zechariah 9–14).

What Is the Book of Zechariah About?

The book of Zechariah has two main sections: Zechariah 1–8 and 9–14.

The first section dates from 520 BC to 518 BC. It contains the oracles and visions of Zechariah, the son of Berechiah. An oracle is a message from God, often delivered through a prophet. It may announce judgment, give instruction, or promise hope. Most of the book of Zechariah is written in prose, or ordinary language rather than poetry. It reassures the Jewish community that returned from exile that the temple will be rebuilt.

The second section, Zechariah 9–14, is undated and does not mention Zechariah. The temple is already standing, and the language is eschatological (related to the end times) and apocalyptic (revealing hidden truths). This section itself divides into two parts: Zechariah 9–11 and 12–14. Zechariah 9 and 12 both start with "This is the burden of the word of the LORD."

The first part of Zechariah (Zechariah 1–8) has four main sections:

1. the introduction and first message (Zechariah 1:1–6);
2. eight night visions and related messages (Zechariah 1:7–6:8);
3. the symbolic crowning of Joshua (Zechariah 6:9–15); and
4. the question about fasting and right and wrong conduct (Zechariah 7:1–8:23).

The Introduction and First Message (1:1–6)

This section refers to the "eighth month" of the Babylonian calendar, which spans from mid-October to mid-November. The second year of Darius, king of Persia, was 520 BC. This date is important for connecting Zechariah's work with Haggai's (see Haggai 1:1, 15; 2:1, 10, 18–20) and the temple reconstruction under Zerubbabel. The first oracle emphasizes the need for repentance. Zechariah's first message came between Haggai's second and third messages. Like Haggai, Zechariah likely believed that crop failures and other hardships resulted from not rebuilding the temple (see Haggai 1:6–11). Zechariah urges the people to repent so they can continue working on the temple.

The Eight Night Visions and Related Oracles (1:7–6:8)

Zechariah saw these visions in Jerusalem on the night of the 24th day of the 11th month (Shebat) in the second year of Darius, which is mid-January to mid-February 519 BC. Seven of the eight visions have a similar structure. Four visions start with "Then I looked up and saw" (Zechariah 1:18; 2:1; 5:1; 6:1). One begins with "I looked out into the night" (Zechariah 1:8). Another starts with "Then the angel who was speaking with me returned and woke me, as a man is awakened from his sleep. "'What do you see?' he asked" (Zechariah 4:1–2).

Yet another (the seventh) vision starts with "Then the angel who was speaking with me came forward and told me…" (Zechariah 5:5). However, the fourth vision is different. It begins with "Then the angel showed me" (Zechariah 3:1; compare Amos 7:1, 4, 7). Unlike several other visions, this vision does not follow the usual pattern of Zechariah asking an angel to explain what he sees. This fourth vision is so different from the others that it was not part of the original series of eight.

There is no clear pattern in the eight visions. Some scholars find significance in the shift from night in the first vision to sunrise in the last. Others see connections between pairs of visions. The first and last visions involve horses, riders, or chariots. The second and third visions focus on restoring Judah and Jerusalem (Zechariah 1:18–21; 2:1–5).

The fourth and fifth visions discuss the roles of two leaders in the restored community/ Joshua will be cleansed and restored as high priest (Zechariah 3:1–5). Zerubbabel, the governor, will complete the temple (Zechariah 4:1–14)

The sixth and seventh visions involve cleansing the land. A flying scroll enters the house of every thief and false witness and destroys it (Zechariah 5:1–4). Wickedness, shown as a woman, will be carried in a basket to the land of Shinar (Zechariah 5:5–11).

Four messages are mixed into the vision accounts (Zechariah 1:14–17; 2:8–13; 3:6–10; 4:8–14). Each oracle starts with "This is what the LORD of Hosts says" or "Proclaim further" (Zechariah 1:14, 17).

The first message promises the renewal of the temple, cities, and God's choice of Jerusalem.

The second message urges exiles in Babylon to return to Judah and Jerusalem (Zechariah 2:7–12). Zechariah 2:12–13 is notable. Zechariah 2:12 is the only Old Testament reference to Palestine as "the Holy Land," and verse 13 resembles the call to worship in Habakkuk 2:20: "Be silent before the LORD, all people, for he has roused himself from his holy dwelling" (Zechariah 2:13).

The third message in the visions is about Joshua the high priest as a sign of the coming of God's servant,

the Branch, who will remove the land's guilt in one day (Zechariah 3:6–10).

The fourth message promises that Zerubbabel will finish the temple and identifies the two anointed ones who serve the Lord (Zechariah 4:8–14).

The Symbolic Crowning of Joshua (6:9–15)
Zechariah is instructed to go to the house of Josiah, son of Zephaniah. He is to take silver and gold from some people returning from Babylon, make a crown, and place it on the head of Joshua the priest. This act symbolizes the ruler who will serve as both king and priest, the Branch, who will build the temple. After the ceremony, the crown will hang in the temple as a memorial to those who gave the silver and gold. The last verse (Zechariah 6:15) suggests that just as exiles contributed gold and silver for the king's crowning, they will also help complete the temple. Then, Zechariah's listeners will know God sent him to prophesy. This will happen if they diligently obey the voice of the Lord.

The Question about Fasting and Morality (7:1–8:23)
A group from Bethel, located 16.1 kilometers (10 miles) north of Jerusalem, visited Jerusalem in the fourth year of Darius in 518 BC. Work on the temple had resumed about two years earlier. They came to ask the Lord to show them kindness (Zechariah 7:2) and to ask the priests and prophets if they should continue fasting as they had since the temple's destruction 70 years earlier (Zechariah 7:3). The Lord instructed Zechariah to question their reasons for fasting. Was their fasting for the Lord or for selfish reasons?

The answer suggests that God values truth, justice, and love more than fasting. Zechariah repeats the message God had given through earlier prophets. The last section of the first part of Zechariah contains ten promises (Zechariah 8:1–23). Each promise starts with "This is what the LORD of Hosts says" or "the word of the LORD of Hosts came to me." God's final message is one of promise, hope, forgiveness, and restoration, not judgment.

The Messages of the Lord (chapters 9–14)
The last half of the book of Zechariah (Zechariah 9–14) is divided into two almost equal parts:

- Zechariah 9–11, which has 46 verses, and
- Zechariah 12–14, which has 44 verses.

Each part starts with the words "the burden" (Zechariah 9:1; 12:1). Both oracles mainly discuss future events.

The first part (Zechariah 9–11) focuses on bringing the tribes back to Palestine (9:11–17; 10:6–12). To achieve this, the Lord will remove opponents from Palestine and Syria (Zechariah 9:1–8; 11:1–3), eliminate corrupt leaders (10:2b–5; 11:4–17), and the Prince of Peace will arrive (9:9–10).

The last oracle of Zechariah (Zechariah 12:1–14:21) also deals with future events, focusing on Jerusalem and Judah. Jerusalem is attacked twice by other nations (Zechariah 12:1–8; 14:1–5). Each time, the Lord defends Jerusalem, Judah, and David's royal family. Jerusalem mourns for an unknown martyr (Zechariah 12:10–14). This martyr might be the "good" shepherd who is killed, causing his followers to scatter (Zechariah 13:7–9).

Jesus mentioned this passage when he was arrested (Matthew 26:31; Mark 14:27). A fountain will open for the house of David, cleansing Jerusalem's people from sin, idolatry, and false prophets (Zechariah 13:1–6). The new Jerusalem will stay elevated, and the surrounding land will become flat (Zechariah 14:10–11). There will be no night or extreme temperatures in the new Jerusalem. Living waters will flow from Jerusalem, and the Lord will become King of the whole earth. Those who fight against Jerusalem will be destroyed, but survivors will worship the Lord each year by celebrating the Feast of Tabernacles (a festival during which the Israelites lived in temporary shelters).

The book ends with a picture of the Lord ruling over the whole earth. Jerusalem will be secure, and everyday objects will be holy to the Lord. Warhorses will be as holy as a priest's turban, and regular cooking pots will be like temple vessels (containers used in temple worship). Traders, referred to as Canaanites, will be gone. People from the surviving nations will come to Jerusalem to worship the Lord as King.

See also History of Israel; Postexilic Period; Prophecy; Prophet, Prophetess; Zechariah (Person) #20.

Zechariah (Person)

An extremely popular name in the Bible. It means "the Lord remembers."

1. The son of King Jeroboam II, 15th king of Israel, and the last king from the Jehu's dynasty. He began his rule in 753 BC, the 38th year of Azariah's reign in Judah (792–740 BC). Zechariah ruled in Samaria for only six months before he was murdered by Shallum at Ibleam (2 Kings 14:29; 15:8–11). The Lord promised Jehu that his descendants would rule to the fourth generation (2 Kings 10:30). This promise was fulfilled with Zechariah's reign.

2. The father of Abi (or Abijah, 2 Chronicles 29:1). Abi was the mother of Hezekiah, who later ruled Judah for 29 years (2 Kings 18:2).
3. A Reubenite and leader of his tribe (1 Chronicles 5:7).
4. A Korahite Levite, the firstborn of Meshelemiah's seven sons and a wise counselor. He was selected by lot to manage the gatekeepers of the sanctuary's northern entrance during David's reign (1 Chronicles 9:21; 26:2, 14).
5. A Benjaminite and descendant of Jeiel (1 Chronicles 9:37). He is also nameed Zeker in 1 Chronicles 8:31, which might be a short form of Zechariah.
6. One of the eight Levites who played a harp before the ark of God in the parade led by David when the ark was brought from Obed-edom's house to Jerusalem (1 Chronicles 15:18, 20; 16:5).
7. One of the priests who blew a trumpet in the parade led by David when the ark was brought to Jerusalem (1 Chronicles 15:24).
8. A levite and a descendant of Isshiah, who served in the sanctuary during David's reign (1 Chronicles 24:25).
9. A Merarite Levite and Hosah's son. He was one of the gatekeepers of the sanctuary's western entrance, at the gate of Halleketh, during David's reign (1 Chronicles 26:11–12, 16).
10. The father of Iddo. Iddo was the leader of the half-tribe of Manasseh in Gilead during David's reign (1 Chronicles 27:21).
11. One of the officials sent by King Jehoshaphat (872–848 BC) to teach the law in the cities of Judah (2 Chronicles 17:7).
12. A Gershonite Levite and Jahaziel's father (2 Chronicles 20:14).
13. One of King Jehoshaphat's seven sons and the brother of Jehoram (2 Chronicles 21:2).
14. The son of Jehoiada the priest. He criticized the princes of Judah for turning against the Lord and worshiping false gods. Enraged by Zechariah's rebuke, they conspired against him, and at King Joash's command, they stoned him to death in the court of the sanctuary (2 Chronicles 24:20–22). he Lord avenged Zechariah's death by allowing the Syrians to defeat Judah, kill the princes, and severely wound Joash, who was subsequently killed by two of his own servants.

In his criticism of his own generation of Jewish leaders, Jesus alluded to Zechariah's murder in the temple grounds: "And so upon you will come all the righteous blood shed on earth, from the blood of righteous Abel to the blood of Zechariah son of Berechiah, whom you murdered between the temple and the altar" (Matthew 23:35). Abel was the first and Zechariah the last of the recorded prophets of God who were unjustly slain, according to the Old Testament.

1. A man who counseled King Uzziah of Judah to walk in the fear of God (2 Chronicles 26:5).
2. A Gershonite Levite descended from Asaph. He and Mattaniah, his kinsman, were chosen by King Hezekiah to help cleanse the house of the Lord (2 Chronicles 29:13).
3. A Kohathite Levite who was appointed to manage the repair of the temple during King Josiah's reign (2 Chronicles 34:12).
4. One of the chief officers of the house of God who generously gave animals to the priests for the celebration of the Passover feast during King Josiah's reign (2 Chronicles 35:8).
5. A prophet. Berechiah's son and the grandson of Iddo. He began prophesying as a young man in 520 BC during the reign of King Darius I of Persia (Zechariah 1:1; compare 2:4). Not much is known about him. We do know that he ministered with Haggai in Jerusalem during the time of Zerubbabel, the governor, and Jeshua, the high priest (Ezra 5:1). This was after the exile in Babylon. Zechariah urged the Jews to finish building the second temple (Ezra 6:14) and led Iddo's priestly family during Joiakim's term as high priest (Nehemiah 12:16). Like Jeremiah and Ezekiel, Zechariah served as both a priest and a prophet (Zechariah 1:1, 7; 7:1, 8).

The accounts of Zechariah's family history do not match exactly. In Ezra and Nehemiah, Iddo is listed as his father, while in Zechariah, Berechiah is mentioned as his father. Some think Berechiah and Iddo might be different names for the same person, or that Berechiah's name (Zechariah 1:1, 7) was added later, confusing him with Jeberechiah's son (compare Isaiah 8:2). A more likely theory is that Iddo was Zechariah's grandfather. Iddo returned to Jerusalem from exile in 538 BC, and Zechariah may have been considered Iddo's successor due to Berechiah's early death or because of Iddo's prominence.

See also Prophet, Prophetess; Zechariah, Book of.

1. Parosh's descendant and the head of his father's household. He returned with Ezra to Judah following the exile in Babylon during the reign of King Artaxerxes I of Persia (Ezra 8:3).
2. Bebai's son and the head of a household. He returned with Ezra to Judah following the exile in Babylon during the reign of King Artaxerxes I of Persia (Ezra 8:11).
3. A Jewish leader. Ezra sent him and other to Iddo, the man in charge at Casiphia, to gather levites

and temple servants for the caravan of Jews returning to Palestine from Babylon (Ezra 8:15–17).
4. One of the six descendants of Elam who was encouraged by Ezra to divorce his foreign wife after the exile in Babylon (Ezra 10:26).
5. One of the men who stood to Ezra's left when Ezra read the law to the people (Nehemiah 8:4).
6. A descendant of Perez and an ancestor of a Judahite family headed by Athaiah. They lived in Jerusalem after the exile in Babylon (Nehemiah 11:4).
7. A descendant of Shelah and an ancestor of a Judahite family headed by Maaseiah. They lived in Jerusalem after the exile in Babylon (Nehemiah 11:5).
8. A priest. A descendant of Malkijah and an ancestor of a family of priests headed by Adaiah. They lived in Jerusalem after the exile in Babylon (Nehemiah 11:12).
9. Jonathan's son, a descendant of Asaph. He led a group of the priestly musicians who played trumpets at the dedication of the Jerusalem wall in Nehemiah's day (Nehemiah 12:35).
10. A priest who played a trumpet at the Jerusalem wall's dedication (Nehemiah 12:41).
11. Jeberechiah's son and an important man who, along with Uriah the priest, witnessed Isaiah's writing of the phrase "Maher-shalal-hash-baz." This phrase later revealed God's intended judgment on Damascus and Samaria (Isaiah 8:2).
12. John the Baptist's father. A priest of Abijah's division, and the husband of Elizabeth, a woman of priestly descent. His story is told in Luke 1. They lived in the Judean hill country during the reign of King Herod the Great (37–4 BC; Luke 1:5). and were known for their righteous and devout lives, though they had no children and were advanced in years.

Zechariah was selected to represent his division in their yearly service at the Jerusalem temple. The priests of Israel were divided into 24 orders, each serving two weeks annually. One day, Zechariah was chosen by lot to burn incense in the temple's Holy Place, an honor given to a priest only once in his lifetime. While he was performing this duty, the angel Gabriel appeared and told him that his wife, Elizabeth, would bear a son named John, who would prepare the way for the Messiah. Zechariah doubted this due to their old age, and as a result, he was made mute (unable to speak) until the prophecy was fulfilled. When Zechariah returned to the temple court, his gestures made the people realize he had seen a vision.

Elizabeth became pregnant as the angel had promised. In her sixth month, she was visited by her relative Mary, who was also expecting a child. After the birth of their son, Zechariah confirmed that the child's name would be John. At that moment, his speech was restored, and he was filled with the Holy Spirit, praising God and prophesying about the significant work God was about to do in Israel.

1. The original name proposed for John the Baptist, after his father's name (Luke 1:59).

See John the Baptist.

Zecher, Zeker

Zehcer is another form of Zechariah, Gibeon's son, in 1 Chronicles 8:31. It is also spelled Zeker.

See Zechariah (Person) #5.

Zedad

Zedad was a place on the northern border of Israel, mentioned between Hamath and Ziphron (Numbers 34:8; Ezekiel 47:15).

Zedekiah

1. Judah's last king and a key political figure in the fateful final decade of the southern kingdom. His reign (597–586 BC) spanned Nebuchadnezzar's two attacks on Jerusalem, in 597 and 586. The first attack was in reprisal for the rebellion of Josiah's son, Jehoiakim (609–598 BC), against Nebuchadnezzar; however, by the time his forces captured Jerusalem, Jehoiakim was dead and had been succeeded by his 18-year-old son Jehoiachin. Nebuchadnezzar deposed the young king and deported him to Babylon, along with the elite of the nation: government officials, army officers, and craftsmen. As Jehoiachin's replacement, Nebuchadnezzar appointed his uncle Mattaniah, a younger brother of Jehoiakim and of the earlier, short-lived King Jehoahaz (609 BC). Mattaniah was thus the third son of Josiah to occupy the throne of Judah. The Babylonian king named him Zedekiah, which means "the Lord is my righteousness."

Zedekiah found himself in a difficult position as Judah's king. Many evidently still regarded Jehoiachin as the real king (cf. Jer 28:1–4). Certainly the Judeans deported to Babylonia dated events by reference to Jehoiachin (2 Kgs 25:27; Ez 1:2). Though the Babylonians exacted from Zedekiah an oath of loyalty (2 Chr 36:13; Ez 17:13–18), evidence suggests that they too viewed Zedekiah's predecessor as the legitimate king and Zedekiah as regent. They may have been holding him in reserve for possible restoration to power, should events require it.

Judah was filled with a false optimism that could hardly have helped the new king. It was confidently expected that the deportation of the leading citizens would be only temporary; prophets were guaranteeing that Babylon's power would be broken within two years (Jer 28:2–4). They were opposed by a few prophets led by Jeremiah, whose message found little support.

Pressure both from within the nation and from without was put on Zedekiah to change his political allegiance. In the fourth year of his reign (593 BC), the neighboring states of Ammon, Moab, Tyre, and Sidon formed a coalition to fight for independence from Babylon. Envoys were sent to Zedekiah (Jer 27:1–3). However, Jeremiah advised the king not to get involved. In the same year, according to Jeremiah 51:59, Zedekiah visited Babylon. He may have been summoned to affirm his loyalty and to explain his role in the political situation. The planned rebellion did not occur, perhaps because aid from Egypt failed to materialize.

Within the Judean court a strong pro-Egyptian party existed. This party saw Egypt as an ally for breaking away from their eastern master, just like the advisers of King Hezekiah a century before (cf. Is 31:1–3; 36:6). Zedekiah, finding it difficult to resist this political pressure, eventually transferred his allegiance to Egypt.

Hophra (589–570 BC), Psammetichus's heir to the Egyptian throne, organized a joint rebellion in the west against Babylon. According to Ezekiel 21:18–32 and 25:12–17, Judah and Ammon supported him, while Edom and Philistia shrewdly abstained. Zedekiah was rebuked by the prophet Ezekiel (Ez 17:13–18) for breaking his oath to Nebuchadnezzar (cf. 2 Chr 36:13) and rebelling against him by sending envoys to Egypt to negotiate for military support.

In the face of this western uprising engineered by his Egyptian rival, Nebuchadnezzar was forced to march westward. Setting up headquarters at Riblah in northern Syria, he decided to make Jerusalem his prime target (Ez 21:18–23). The ensuing siege of Jerusalem was temporarily lifted due to an Egyptian attack but afterward was resumed until the city fell. Zedekiah, fleeing eastward with his troops, was caught near Jericho and taken north to Nebuchadnezzar at Riblah. There he was put on trial for breaking his promises of vassalage. By way of punishment, his sons were killed before his eyes. This tragic sight was the last he ever saw, since his eyes were then put out. He was taken in chains to Babylon, where he eventually died in prison (2 Kgs 25:5–7; Jer 39:7; 52:8–11; cf. Ez 12:13).

See also Chronology of the Bible (Old Testament); Israel, History of.

2. Kenaanah's son and one of the prophets who spoke falsely to kings Ahab of Israel and Jehoshaphat of Judah, telling them that the Lord would give Ahab victory over the Syrians at Ramoth-gilead (1 Kgs 22:11). After hearing Micaiah's contrary prediction that Ahab would in fact be killed in the battle, Zedekiah, in anger, struck Micaiah (v 24).
3. Jeconiah's son and a descendant of David through Solomon's line (1 Chr 3:16).
4. Leading priest who affirmed Nehemiah's covenant during the postexilic era (Neh 10:1).
5. Maaseiah's son, who, according to Jeremiah, King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon would kill by roasting in fire for his adultery and lying words (Jer 29:21–23).
6. Hananiah's son and a prince in Judah during King Jehoiakim's reign (Jer 36:12).

Zeeb

Zeeb was one of two Midianite princes killed by Gideon's army (Judges 7:25).

Zela, Zelah

A city of the tribe of Benjamin where they buried the bones of King Saul and his son Jonathan (Joshua 18:28; 2 Samuel 21:14). Zela was probably the native town of Saul's father, Kish. It may have been the home of Saul before Samuel anointed him king.

Zelek

An Ammonite warrior among the mighty men of King David (2 Samuel 23:37; 1 Chronicles 11:39).

Zelophehad

Zelophehad was the son of Hepher from the tribe of Manasseh. Zelophehad had five daughters but no sons (Numbers 26:33). Because Zelophehad had no sons, his daughters asked Moses to give them the inheritance of their father (27:1). Moses made a ruling that daughters should receive the inheritance in such cases. But, the daughters must marry men from within their own tribe so that the tribal allotments would remain unchanged (Numbers 27:7; 36:2; Joshua 17:3).

Zelotes

The King James Version spelling of "Zealot" in Luke 6:15 and Acts 1:13. Zealot was the additional name of Simon, one of Jesus's 12 disciples.

See Simon #5.

Zelzah

Place near Rachel's tomb where Saul met two men in fulfillment of Samuel's prophecy concerning the events that would confirm Saul's anointing (1 Sm 10:2). Rachel's tomb is traditionally located at the northern border of Benjamin, but no precise identification of Zelzah has been made. Some have argued that Zelzah and Zela are the same place, but this is unlikely.

Zemaraim

1. Town near the northern border of the territory of Benjamin (Jos 18:22). The most likely location is Ras ez-Zeimara, about five miles (8 kilometers) northeast of Bethel in the hill country between et-Taiyibeh and Rammum.
2. Mountain in the hill country of Ephraim (2 Chr 13:4) and the scene of Abijah's speech of rebuke against Jeroboam and the Israelites.

Zemarites

One of the families of the Canaanites in the ethnological lists of Genesis 10 (v 18) and 1 Chronicles 1 (v 16). The Zemarites were a Hamitic tribe mentioned in connection with the Arvadites and the Hamathites. They were probably located near the Mediterranean in the vicinity of Tripoli.

Zemirah

Zemirah was Beker's firstborn son, from the tribe of Benjamin (1 Chronicles 7:8).

Zenan

Zenan was one of the cities in the Shephelah hill lands that Judah received (Joshua 15:37).

Zenas

Lawyer whom Paul asked Titus to help with his travels in Crete (Titus 3:13).

Zephaniah (Person)

1. Priest during the reign of Zedekiah who was executed at Riblah by the king of Babylon (2 Kgs 25:18; Jer 52:24). He was the second priest under Seraiah the chief priest and served as Zedekiah's envoy to Jeremiah during the period prior to the fall of Jerusalem (Jer 21:1; 29:25–29; 37:3).
2. Ancestor of Heman who was among the Kohathite Levites whom David placed in charge of the service of music in the house of the Lord (1 Chr 6:33–36). Zephaniah is listed as the father of Azariah and the son of Tahath.
3. Author of the book of Zephaniah (Zep 1:1). Though little is known about Zephaniah, it is possible that his ancestor Hezekiah is the same as the king by that name. See Zephaniah, Book of.
4. Father of Josiah in whose house Joshua was crowned as high priest (Zec 6:10–14).

Zephath

Zephath was a Canaanite city that was conquered by the tribes of Judah and Simeon. After they captured it, they renamed it Hormah (Judges 1:17). was the place where the Israelites first tried to enter Canaan but failed. This happened when they disobeyed the command of Moses. As a result, the Amalekites and the Canaanites defeated them (Numbers 14:45).

See also Hormah.

Zephathah

Valley where Asa defeated Zerah the Ethiopian (2 Chr 14:10). The valley of Zephathah is located in the vicinity of Mareshah and thus in southwestern Judah.

Zepho

Zepho was a son of Eliphaz and a descendant of Esau (Genesis 36:11, 15; 1 Chronicles 1:36).

Zephon

Zephon was the firstborn son of Gad and the father of the Zephonite clan (Genesis 46:16; Numbers 26:15).

Zer

One of the fortified cities of Naphtali's tribe (Jos 19:35). From the surrounding names in the list, it may be inferred that it was located on the southwest side of the Sea of Galilee.

Zerah

1. One of the chiefs of the Edomites (Genesis 36:17; 1 Chronicles 1:37). He is the son of Reuel, Esau's son by his wife Basemath. He was likely the ancestor of Jobab, who later became king of the Edomites (Genesis 36:13, 33).
2. One of the twin sons of Judah by his daughter-in-law Tamar (Genesis 38:30; 46:12; Matthew 1:3). Although Zerah thrust out his hand first, he drew it back, allowing his brother, Perez, to be born first. The descendants of Zerah (the Zerahites) became one of the most influential clans of Judah (Numbers

26:20; Joshua 7:1, 18; 22:20; 1 Chronicles 2:4–6; 9:6). Because Ethan and Heman are listed as sons of Zerah in 1 Chronicles 2:6, the Ezrahites mentioned in 1 Kings 4:31 and the titles to Psalms 88 and 89 are also considered to be Zerahites. However, Ethan and Heman are listed as Levites in 1 Chronicles 15:17. It is more likely that the Ezrahites were a Levite clan.
3. One of the sons of Simeon from whom the Zerahite clan descended (Numbers 26:13; 1 Chronicles 4:24). He is also called Zohar in Genesis 46:10 and Exodus 6:15.
4. One of the sons of Iddo, from the Gershonite branch of Levi's tribe (1 Chronicles 6:21).
5. One of the ancestors of Asaph from Levi's tribe. He is the son of Adaiah and the father of Ethni (1 Chronicles 6:41). Several believe him to be the same individual as #4 above.
6. The commander of the Ethiopians (Cushites) who fought against Asa, king of Judah (2 Chronicles 14:9). It is hard to identify this person or the event with any certainty. The most common identification has been with Usarkon II of Egypt. The battle account matches Usarkon's reign in Egypt. So do the troops' numbers and nationalities.

Zerahiah

1. Uzzi's son and ancestor of Ezra from the priestly line of Eleazar (1 Chr 6:6, 51; Ezr 7:4).
2. Father of Eliehoenai, who was head of a family who returned to Jerusalem with Ezra (Ezr 8:4).

Zerahite

1. Any descendant of Zerah, son of Simeon (Numbers 26:13). See Zerah #3.
2. Any descendant of Zerah, son of the Judah by Tamar (Numbers 26:20). See Zerah #2.

See also Izrahite.

Zered

Valley and brook by which the Israelites encamped, listed between Iye-abarim and a stopping place near the Arnon River to the north (Nm 21:12). Though its exact location remains in question, Zered is probably identifiable with the modern Wadi el-Hesa, a streambed that formed a natural border between the ancient countries of Moab and Edom and, following a northwestward course, emptied into the southern end of the Dead Sea. The crossing of the Zered Brook by the Israelites marked 38 years since Israel rebelled against God at Kadesh-barnea (Dt 2:13–14).

Zereda

The King James Version spelling of Zeredah in 1 Kings 11:26.

See Zeredah #1.

Zeredah

1. The birthplace (or hometown) of Jeroboam, Israel's first king during the period of the divided kingdom (1 Kings 11:26).
2. A city in the Jordan Valley (2 Chronicles 4:17; "Zarethan" in 1 Kings 7:46).

See Zarethan.

Zeredathah

Zeredathah is the King James Version spelling of Zeredah in 2 Chronicles 4:17.

See Zeredah #2.

Zererah

Zererah was a city mentioned in the account of Gideon's defeat of the Midianites (Judges 7:22). It may also be another name for Zarethan.

Zeresh

The wife of Haman the Agagite. She told him to build the gallows (a tall wooden structure) for hanging Mordecai (Esther 5:10, 14).

Zereth

Zereth was Asshur's son by his wife Helah from the tribe of Judah (1 Chronicles 4:7).

Zereth-shahar

Zereth-shahar was one of the cities given to the tribe of Reuben for an inheritance (Joshua 13:19). The city is described as being on "the hill in the valley."

Zeri

One of the sons of Jeduthun who prophesied with the lyre in thanksgiving to the Lord (1 Chr 25:3). He may be the same person as Izri (v 11).

Zeror

Zeror was a man from the tribe of Benjamin. He was Becorath's son, the father of Abiel, and an ancestor of King Saul (1 Samuel 9:1).

Zeruah

The mother of Israel's King Jeroboam I (1 Kings 11:26).

Zerubbabel

A Jewish man born in Babylon. He returned to Palestine in 538 BC to be the Persian-appointed governor of Jerusalem. His name likely means "seed [offspring] of Babylon," indicating his birthplace in Babylon.

There is some uncertainty about Zerubbabel's biological father. Most biblical references identify Shealtiel as his father (Ezra 3:2, 8; 5:2; Nehemiah 12:1; Haggai 1:1, 12–14; 2:2, 23; Matthew 1:12–13; Luke 3:27), making Zerubbabel the grandson of King Jehoiachin of the Davidic line. However, 1 Chronicles 3:19 names Pedaiah, Shealtiel's brother, as his father.

Two possible explanations have been suggested:

1. Shealtiel died without having children, and Pedaiah fathered Zerubbabel with Shealtiel's widow according to the levirate marriage law, where a brother would marry his dead brother's widow (Deuteronomy 25:5–10). In this case, Zerubbabel would be listed as Shealtiel's son to preserve his lineage. However, the text does not strongly support this theory. The Chronicler does not mention this detail if it was meant to clarify Zerubbabel's parentage.
2. The Septuagint (the Greek translation of the Hebrew Bible) 6lists Shealtiel as Zerubbabel's father in 1 Chronicles 3:19. This aligns with the other references and may resolve the discrepancy.

Zerubbabel was of Davidic descent, whether his father was Shealtiel or Pedaiah. He was seen as a potential leader to restore the Israelite community.

In 538 BC, Cyrus the Great allowed the Jews to return home. He then appointed Zerubbabel as governor of Jerusalem. By around 529–520 BC, he began work on rebuilding the Jerusalem temple. However, progress was slow due to various setbacks, and significant progress did not occur until 520 BC.

The prophets Haggai and Zechariah show Zerubbabel's key role in the community. They viewed Zerubbabel and Jeshua (the high priest) as God's chosen leaders for the task of rebuilding. Their support is evident in their writings (for example, Haggai 2:21–23; Zechariah 3:8; 4:6–7; 6:12), where the work of these two men is depicted as having messianic significance. This is clear in Zechariah's vision (Zechariah 4:11–14). Two olive branches beside the lampstand are "the two anointed ones who are standing beside the Lord of all the earth." These are Jeshua and Zerubbabel.

Zerubbabel's work to rebuild Jerusalem's temple earned him great honor in Jewish tradition. Some scholars believe the Persians might have known Zerubbabel as Sheshbazzar.

See Sheshbazzar.

Zeruiah

A daughter of Nahash and the sister of Abigail (2 Samuel 17:25). Zeruiah later gave birth to three sons: Joab, Abishai, and Asahel. All of them were friends of David when he was king of Israel (2 Samuel 2:18; 3:39; 8:16; 18:2).

Zetham

Zetham was a descendant of Ladan and a member of the Gershonite family. He was in charge of the temple treasuries (1 Chronicles 23:8; 26:22).

Zethan

Zethan was Bilhan's son from the tribe of Benjamin (1 Chronicles 7:10).

Zethar

One of seven trusted palace officials (called chamberlains) who served King Ahasuerus of Persia. The king ordered Zethar and the other officials to bring Queen Vashti to a feast so everyone could see her beauty (Esther 1:10).

Zeus

Chief god of the Greek pantheon (Roman Jupiter). Zeus was initially worshiped as part of an animistic cult, as the sky god with thunder as his principal manifestation. Well before the time of Homer, however, Zeus had become the preeminent personal god of the Greek residents of Thessaly, with Mt Olympus serving as the focal point of the cult. By NT times, Zeus was considered the Greek father god who possessed supreme powers. The quotation Paul used in Acts 17:28 from Cleanthes (and/or Aratus) was originally ascribed to Zeus ("in him we live and move and have our being").

Zeus is most significant in biblical writings as a result of Paul and Barnabas's encounter with the priest of Zeus at Lystra (Acts 14:8–18). Because Paul and Barnabas had healed a lame man, the residents of Lystra attempted to worship them, identifying Barnabas with Zeus and Paul with Hermes, the messenger of the gods. It was not unusual that this misidentification should take place, since the Greek gods were frequently represented as taking on human appearances and intervening directly in human affairs. Unlike the true God, Zeus and his consorts were often viewed as capriciously bestowing favor or disfavor. The attribution of "divinity" to Paul and Barnabas allowed them to identify the key differences between Greek and Christian theology.

Zia

Zia was one of the clan leaders of the tribe of Gad who lived in Bashan (1 Chronicles 5:13).

Ziba

Ziba was a former servant of King Saul. After Saul died, David became king. David asked Ziba to find any people still alive from Saul's family. David wanted to show kindness to them (2 Samuel 9:2–12).

During the time after Saul's death, Ziba gained his freedom. He also became a wealthy landowner. But this changed when Ziba told David about Mephibosheth, the disabled son of Jonathan. David gave Mephibosheth back the land that had belonged to Saul's family.

Later, Ziba and Mephibosheth had a disagreement. It happened when David had to flee from Jerusalem during Absalom's rebellion. Ziba met David with supplies and claimed that Mephibosheth stayed behind because he hoped to take back the throne (2 Samuel 16:1–4). When David returned, Mephibosheth came to meet him. He said that Ziba had lied and had left him behind on purpose because he could not travel easily (19:17, 24–29).

Most Bible scholars think Ziba lied and spoke badly about Mephibosheth. But the Bible does not clearly say who was guilty. It seems unlikely that Mephibosheth thought he could become king, even though Ziba said this (2 Samuel 16:3). Mephibosheth also seemed loyal to David. However, David may have brought him to Jerusalem to keep a close watch on him. On the other hand, David believed Ziba's claim without asking questions. This shows David may have thought Mephibosheth wanted the throne. Ziba also continued to support David, even though David's decision had taken away Ziba's land and freedom (2 Samuel 16:1; 19:17).

Ziba may have been unhappy about losing his freedom. This could have led him to say false things about Mephibosheth. In the end, David seemed unsure about who was telling the truth. So he did not fully support either one. Instead, he decided to divide the land between them (2 Samuel 19:29).

Zibeon

Ancestor of Oholibamah, the Canaanite wife of Esau (Gn 36:2, 14). He is listed as a Hivite in Genesis 36:2 but is probably the same as Zibeon the son of Seir the Horite (Gn 36:20, 29; 1 Chr 1:38). Possibly "Hivite" designated his tribal affiliation, while "Horite" indicated the fact that he dwelt in caves. It is also possible that "Hivite" is a transmission error in Genesis 36:2.

Zibia

Zibia was one of the seven sons of Shaharaim and his wife Hodesh (1 Chronicles 8:9).

Zibiah

The mother of King Jehoash of Judah. She was from the town of Beersheba (2 Kings 12:1; 2 Chronicles 24:1).

Zichri, Zicri

1. A Kohathite Levite and a descendant of Izhar (Exodus 6:21).
2. One of Shimei's sons from the tribe of Benjamin (1 Chronicles 8:19).
3. One of Shashak's sons from the tribe of Benjamin (1 Chronicles 8:23).
4. One of Jeroham's sons from the tribe of Benjamin (1 Chronicles 8:27).
5. An ancestor of Mattaniah. Mattaniah returned with Zerubbabel to Israel following the exile in Babylon (1 Chronicles 9:15). Zicri is probably Zabdi from Nehemiah 11:17.
6. A descendant of Eliezer, the son of Moses. His son, Shelomoth, was in charge of the treasuries of the dedicated gifts (1 Chronicles 26:25).
7. The father of Eliezer, the chief officer of the Reubenites during David's reign (1 Chronicles 27:16).
8. The father of Amasiah, a volunteer in charge of 200,000 men during Jehoshaphat's reign (2 Chronicles 17:16).
9. The father of Elishaphat, a member of the conspiracy against Athaliah led by Jehoiada (2 Chronicles 23:1).
10. A mighty man from Ephraim who participated in Pekah's domination of Judah. Zicri killed Ahaz's son Maaseiah, Azrikam the commander of the palace, and Elkanah the king's deputy (2 Chronicles 28:7).
11. The father of Joel, overseer of the Benjaminites who returned to Jerusalem following the exile in Babylon (Nehemiah 11:9).
12. A Levite who served as a priest and the head of the clan of Abijah during the days of Joiakim the high priest (Nehemiah 12:17).

Ziddim

Ziddim was a fortified city in the land of Naphtali (Joshua 19:35).

Zidkijah

Zidkijah is the King James Version form of Zedekiah, a priest mentioned in Nehemiah 10:1.

See Zedekiah #4.

Zidon, Zidonian

Zidon and Zidonian are the forms used in the King James Version for Sidon and Sidonian. Sidon is a city, and the Sidonians are its people. The city was in the territory of Asher.

See Sidon (Place), Sidonian.

Zif

The King James Version form of Ziv, the name of the Hebrew month that occurs from around mid-April to mid-May (1 Kings 6:1, 37).

See Calendars, Ancient and Modern.

Ziggurat

A word meaning "temple tower." A ziggurat looked similar to the step pyramid of Egypt and was used for worship.

Ziggurats were often built in the major cities of Mesopotamia. The Tower of Babel is believed to have been based on this kind of building (Genesis 11:1–9).

It was widely believed that gods lived in high places. Therefore, worship was more appropriate on hills or mountains. But there were no hills or suitable building stones in Mesopotamia, so the Mesopotamians built with mud bricks. The ziggurats of mud brick were constructed to be like hills where the worshiper or priest could get closer to the gods.

Like the pyramids of Egypt, these temple towers were square. Instead of having sloping sides, it had a series of terraces that decreased in size as they ascended. Stairways or ramps provided access to each level, and the top level housed a shrine or altar where priests conducted religious ceremonies. The great seven-story ziggurat at Babylon measured nearly 300 feet (91.4 meters) on a side at the base and rose to about the same height.

Ziha

1. Ancestor of a family of temple servants who returned to Jerusalem with Zerubbabel after the exile (Ezr 2:43; Neh 7:46).
2. Overseer of the temple servants living at Ophel during the postexilic era (Neh 11:21). If Ziha is simply a family name, then this person is likely the same as #1 above.

Ziklag

Philistine city ruled by David for 16 months before he moved to Hebron to become the king of Judah. Ziklag was deeded to David by Achish of Gath, presumably to ensure David's continued neutrality (1 Sm 27:6; 1 Chr 12:1). The location of Ziklag is difficult to determine despite its prominence in the early history of Israel. In the record of the land allotments following the Conquest, Ziklag appears to be located in the extreme south of Judah (Jos 15:31). It is later described as part of the allotment within western Judah that was granted to Simeon (Jos 19:5; 1 Chr 4:30). Ziklag was most likely located somewhere on the frontier between Philistia and Judah, southeast of Gaza (possibly Tell el-Khuweilfeh).

Zillah

Zillah was the second wife of Lamech and mother of Tubal-cain and Naamah (Genesis 4:19–23).

Zillethai

1. One of Shimei's sons from Benjamin's tribe (1 Chr 8:20).
2. One of the "chiefs of thousands" who deserted Saul and came to David at Ziklag (1 Chr 12:20).

Zilpah

Mother of Jacob's sons Gad and Asher. Laban had given her to his daughter Leah as a handmaid (Gn 29:24; 46:18). Later, at Leah's insistence, she became Jacob's concubine for the purpose of bearing sons (30:9; 37:2).

Zilthai

Zilthai is the King James Version spelling of Zillethai in 1 Chronicles 8:20 and 12:20.

See Zillethai #1 and #2.

Zimmah

Zimmah was a Gershonite Levite and ancestor of Joah (1 Chronicles 6:20). He may be the same Joah who helped Hezekiah (2 Chronicles 29:12).

Zimran

One of the sons of Abraham by Keturah (Gn 25:2; 1 Chr 1:32). Unlike the other sons of Abraham by Keturah, there is little evidence that Zimran is associated with a later tribal group.

Zimri (Person)

1. A leader of the Simeon tribe who was killed by Phinehas for having an improper relationship with a Midianite woman at Peorr (Numbers 25:14). Zimri's sin was considered worse because he did it openly, he was a tribal leader, and the woman was the daughter of an important Midianite prince.
2. A king of Israel who ruled for only seven days (in 885 BC). He became king after he killed King Elah and all of Baasha's family (1 Kings 16:9–12). Zimri was the commander of half of the chariot forces, but he failed to get support from the people. Instead, the people supported Omri, who was the commander of the army. When Omri attacked Zimri at Tirzah, Zimri killed himself by setting fire to his palace (16:15–18). Later, Queen Jezebel referred to Zimri's cruelty when she accused Jehu of being like Zimri (2 Kings 9:31).
3. One of the sons of Zerah. Zerach was a son of Judah by Tamar (1 Chronicles 2:6). Another name for him is Zabdi in the parallel passage in Joshua 7:1, 17.

See Zabdi #1.

1. A descendant of King Saul from the tribe of Benjamin. 1 Chronicles 8:36 lists him as the son of Jehoaddah and the father of Moza. This Zimri is likely the same as Zimri the son of Jadah (9:42).

Zimri (Place)

Place and peoples of the East, listed along with Elam and Media, against whom God's wrath would fall (Jer 25:25). Zimri's location and history are unknown; some identify its progenitor with Zimran, Abraham and Keturah's son (Gn 25:2).

Zina

Zina is another form of Ziza, Shimei's son, in 1 Chronicles 23:10.

See Ziza.

Zinc

A chemical element that is a type of metal.

See Minerals and Metals.

Zion

The Jebusite fortress in Jerusalem conquered by David. Thereafter, Zion was used by biblical writers to identify other areas of Jerusalem and was used as a designation of the entire city. Zion was also used to describe, spiritually speaking, the eternal city of God.

Geographical Sites

The Jebusite Fortress

The first occurrence of the word "Zion" is in the narrative of David's conquest of Jerusalem (2 Sm 5:6–10; 1 Chr 11:4–9). David captured the "fortress of Zion," which was thereafter known as the "city of David." The "fortress of Zion" may refer to the entire walled perimeter of the approximately 11-acre (4.5-hectare) site on the southeastern ridge (the Ophel Ridge), or to a smaller fortified area within that site.

The Temple Mount

Changes in the perimeter of the city by incorporating more territory within the walls extend the term Zion. When Solomon built the temple and his palace and extended the walls north of the Ophel Ridge to encompass the threshing floor of Ornan the Jebusite (2 Sm 24:16–18; 1 Chr 21:15–18, 28), the name Zion was applied to these areas as well. The transfer of the ark "from the city of David which is Zion" (1 Kgs 8:1; 2 Chr 5:2) to the temple hill brought both an extension and a reduction of the territory embraced by the term "Zion." The whole city could still be called Zion, but from this point on, there would be a close identification between Zion and the temple hill. The temple precincts became the primary Zion; references to Zion in the poetic books and the preaching of the prophets are primarily to the temple area as the dwelling place of God.

The Entire City

The word "Zion" can be used as a designation of the entire city or its population without any particular reference to the temple area. This use is clearest in poetic passages where Zion is the parallel term to Jerusalem (Pss 51:18; 76:2; 102:21; 135:21; 147:12; Is 2:3; 30:19; 33:20; 37:32; 40:9; 41:27; 62:1; Jer 26:18; 51:35; Am 1:2; Zep 3:14) or to the villages of Judah (Pss 69:35; 97:8; Is 40:9).

Theological Motifs

In the Old Testament

Many theological motifs attach to the Zion theme as it develops in redemptive history. The dominant motif of Zion as the dwelling place of God, the place where God is in the midst of his people, is conjoined to the larger theme of Immanuel, "God in our midst." Just as the pillar of fire and cloud stood above the tabernacle during the wilderness wandering, so once Israel had attained the place of God's choosing (Dt 12:5–14), he would dwell there. When Jerusalem became David's capital and Solomon had completed the temple, the glory cloud filled the temple (1 Kgs 8:10; 2 Chr 5:13–14) and Jerusalem became the dwelling place of God (Pss 74:2; 76:2; 135:21; Is 8:18; Jl 3:17–21). The Lord loved and

chose Zion (Pss 78:68; 132:13). His glorious presence was there, and from there he would speak (50:1–2). His fire was in Zion, his furnace in Jerusalem (Is 31:8–9). There he was enthroned above the cherubim (Pss 9:11; 99:1–2) and ruled over his people and the nations (Is 24:23). His chosen king ruled from that holy hill (Pss 2:6; 48:1).

Though the size of the site of ancient Jerusalem is not particularly impressive and ordinarily would not be considered a large hill, for the psalmist Zion is God's holy hill (Ps 99:9). The prophets describe it as "chief among the mountains, raised above the hills" (Is 2:2; Mi 4:1). The Canaanite god Baal was thought to dwell on a great mountain to the north, Mt Zaphon, so the psalmist describes Zion as "beautiful in its loftiness, like the utmost heights of Mt Zaphon" (Ps 48:1–2). God's sanctuary is "like the high mountains" (Ps 78:68; Ez 40:2).

An adequate water supply has been a problem for Jerusalem throughout its history. During the OT period, the city's water came from one small spring. But in the eyes of the poets and prophets, Zion is gladdened by a great river that brings life wherever it flows (Ps 46:4; Ez 47:1–12; Jl 3:18; Zec 13:1; 14:8; see Rv 22:1–2). The threatening waters of chaos cannot shake the city of God (Ps 46:1–3).

Because Zion is the city of God, it is the object of pilgrims, Jew and Gentile alike, who thirst to be in the presence of God in Zion's temple (Pss 42:1–2; 63:1). The pilgrim psalms give vivid expression to their longing (84; 122; 125–128). All humanity will come to God in Zion (65:1–4). The Gentiles will make annual pilgrimages bringing gifts (Ps 76; Is 18:7; Zep 3:9–10); even former enemies will be regarded as native-born citizens of Zion (Ps 87; Is 60:14; Zec 14:21). The nations will stream into Jerusalem to inaugurate an era of peace (Is 2:1–5; Mi 4:1–8). Year after year the festivals of Israel will be celebrated in Zion by Gentiles (Zec 14:16–19).

In the New Testament

The NT further develops the emphasis on both the heavenly and the eschatological Zion. For example, the author of Hebrews said that the OT saints looked "forward to the city with foundations, whose architect and builder is God . . . longing for a better country —a heavenly one" (Heb 11:10, 16, niv), but none of them received the promises because God had planned something even better (vv 39–40). The church now enjoys what believers of the old covenant could never know: unlimited access to the presence of God in that Holy City, "Mount Zion, the heavenly Jerusalem, the city of the living God" (12:22; see vv 18–24). Earthly Zion is but a shadow of the heavenly reality. The present city of Jerusalem is likened to a slave woman, but the heavenly Jerusalem is free and the mother of both Jew and Gentile (Gal 4:21–27; see Is 49:14–23; 54:1). The NT also looks forward to the eschatological expectation of the re-creation of heaven and earth and the revelation of the new Jerusalem (Rv 21:2). It is a city on a great high mountain (Rv 21:10; see Pss 48:1–2; 78:68; Is 2:2; Ez 40:2; Mi 4:1), and a river of life flows within (Rv 22:1–2).

See also Jerusalem; Jerusalem, New.

Zior

One of the cities of the hill country allotted to Judah's tribe for an inheritance (Jos 15:54). Since it is associated with Hebron in the text, Zior is likely identified with modern Sa'ir, the traditional location for Esau's tomb.

Ziph (Person)

1. Descendant of Caleb from Judah's tribe (1 Chr 2:42).
2. One of the sons of Jehallelel from Judah's tribe (1 Chr 4:16).

Ziph (Place)

1. One of the cities in the extreme south assigned to Judah's tribe for an inheritance (Jos 15:24).
2. One of the cities in the hill country belonging to Judah's tribe (Jos 15:55), mentioned with Maon, Carmel, Jezreel, and most prominently with Hebron (cf. 1 Chr 2:42). Ziph has been identified with a site three miles (4.8 kilometers) south of Hebron. The surrounding wilderness region is probably the "wilderness of Ziph" where David hid from Saul (1 Sm 23:14–15; 26:2). The Ziphites who betrayed David to Saul were residents of this city and the surrounding region (1 Sm 23:19; 26:1; Ps 54 title). Ziph is later mentioned as one of the cities fortified by Rehoboam (2 Chr 11:8).

Ziphah

Ziphah was the second child of Jehallelel (1 Chronicles 4:16). Ziphah may have been a son or a daughter because the form of the name is feminine.

Ziphims

Ziphims is the King James Version form of Ziphites, people who lived in Ziph, in the title of Psalm 54.

See Ziph (Place) #2.

Ziphite

Ziphite was a person who lived in Ziph (1 Samuel 23:19; 26:1; Psalm 54:1).

See Ziph (Place) #2.

Ziphron

A geographical landmark defining the northern boundary of the Canaanite land that Israel would possess (Numbers 34:9).

Zippor

The father of Balak, who was the king of Moab. Balak asked a man named Balaam to curse the Israelites (Numbers 22:2, 10, 16; 23:18; Joshua 24:9; Judges 11:25).

Zipporah

The wife of Moses and mother of his sons, Gershom and Eliezer (Exodus 2:21). Zipporah is listed as the daughter of Reuel (Exodus 2:18). But, Reuel was probably the father of Hobab, who was the father of Zipporah (Numbers 10:29; called Jethro in Exodus 3:1; 4:18). So, Reuel would have been Zipporah's grandfather.

Zipporah circumcised Gershom to prevent Moses' death before his return to Egypt (Exodus 4:25). Apparently at that point Zipporah and the children left Moses and went back to live with her father, returning later during the time Israel wandered in the wilderness (Exodus 18:2).

Zither

A zither is a musical instrument with many strings stretched across a flat wooden body. A person plays it by plucking or striking the strings. Some Bible translations use "zither" in Daniel 3:5, 7, and 15 for a stringed instrument played at the Babylonian king's command. The exact form of this ancient instrument is not certain. It may have been more like a lyre.

See Musical Instruments.

Zithri

The King James Version spelling of Sithri, Uzziel's son, in Exodus 6:22.

See Sithri.

Ziv

The name of the Hebrew month that occurs around mid-April to mid-May (1 Kings 6:1, 37). It was the second month of the ancient Israelite calendar. In later times, this month was called Iyyar.

See Calendars, Ancient and Modern.

Ziz, Ascent of

Mountain pass going up from the Dead Sea to the Judean highlands. This ascent was the route used by the Ammonites and the Moabites prior to their defeat by Jehoshaphat as prophesied by Jehaziel (2 Chr 20:16). It is likely that Ziz should be identified with Ain Jidy, a pass that still provides an important route from the Dead Sea into the Judean interior.

Ziza

1. Chief of Simeon's tribe descending from Shemaiah (1 Chr 4:37).
2. Son of Rehoboam and Maacah (2 Chr 11:20).
3. Second of Shimei's sons and a clan chief within the Gershonite branch of Levi's tribe (1 Chr 23:11); perhaps the same as Zina in 1 Chronicles 23:10.

Zoan

One of the principal cities in the delta region of ancient Egypt. Zoan, which was variously known as Zoan, Tanis, Avaris, and possibly Rameses (the towns were either the same or contiguous), was located on the south shore of Lake Menzaleh at the northeastern edge of the Egyptian Delta. Zoan was rebuilt during or shortly before the Hyksos period (c. 1730 BC; Nm 13:22). Because of its strategic location on the Tanitic branch of the Nile and near Egypt's northeastern frontier, Zoan was an important military and political base during the entire period of Egyptian native rule. It served as the capital city during the Hyksos period, as well as serving as the effective capital during the 21st through the 23d dynasties (c. 1090–718 BC) and as the northern capital during the 25th dynasty (c. 712–663 BC).

Zoan was significant to the Israelites during each of its periods of ascendancy. Whether the exodus occurred early (c. 1441 BC) or late (1290 BC), the Israelite settlement in Egypt would have been in the general vicinity of Zoan. The Israelites built the store cities of Pithom and Rameses, and possibly the latter should be identified with Zoan. In the account of the exodus in Psalm 78, the city of Zoan is poetically parallel to Egypt, indicating that it was either the capital or at least a significant city. During the period of Isaiah, Zoan was again significant, being designated as the home of the "princes" and "officials" of Egypt (Is 19:11–13; Ez 30:14).

See also Rameses (Place).

Zoar

Zoar was one of the "cities of the plain." It was allied with Sodom, Gomorrah, Admah, and Zeboiim (Genesis 14:2, 8). Its earlier name was Bela.

Zoar is best known as the town where Lot and his daughters found temporary safety when God destroyed Sodom and the other cities of the plain (Genesis 19:22–23, 30). Zoar was probably a small town. Its name means "little" (verse 22). Even so, it seems to have been an important location in ancient times.

When Abraham and Lot divided the land, Lot chose the area near Zoar (Genesis 13:10). When Moses looked at the promised land from Mount Pisgah, Zoar marked the southern end of the plain near the Jordan Valley and Jericho (Deuteronomy 34:3). During the time of the prophets, Zoar seems to have been near the southern border of Moab (Isaiah 15:5; Jeremiah 48:4, 34).

See also Cities of the Plain.

Zobah

Zobah was an Aramean nation that was defeated by Israel during the early kingdom period. King Saul won battles against the kings of Zobah (1 Samuel 14:47).

Soon after David became king of Israel, he defeated Hadadezer the son of Rehob, king of Zobah (2 Samuel 8:3–5, 12; 1 Chronicles 18:3–10; Psalm 60 title). Later, the Ammonites hired 20,000 Aramean foot soldiers from Beth-rehob and Zobah for an anticipated attack by the military forces of David. Joab led Israel's army and defeated the combined forces of the Ammonites and their hired Aramean allies (2 Samuel 10:6–14). Afterward, Hadadezer sent reinforcements, but David himself led Israel to another victory over the Arameans (2 Samuel 10:15–19; 1 Chronicles 19:16–19).

Zobebah

One of the sons of Koz (or possibly a daughter, since the noun is feminine) from Judah's tribe (1 Chr 4:8). The genealogy is obscure.

Zodiac

A circle of twelve groups of stars (called constellations) used in astrology to predict events or describe personality. In the ancient world around Israel, the zodiac was part of pagan worship and fortune-telling. The Bible forbids God's people to seek guidance from these practices (Isaiah 47:13–14).

See Astrology; see also Constellation.

Zohar

1. The father of Ephron the Hittite. Abraham bought the cave of Machpelah from Ephron (Genesis 23:7–9; 25:9).
2. An alternate spelling of Zerah, Simeon's son, in Genesis 46:10 and Exodus 6:15.

See Zerah #3.

1. An alternate spelling of Izhar in 1 Chronicles 4:7.

Zoheth

Zoheth was Ishi's son from the tribe of Judah (1 Chronicles 4:20).

Zophah

Zophah was Helem's son from the tribe of Asher (1 Chronicles 7:35–36).

Zophai

Zophai is another spelling of Zuph, one of Samuel's ancestors, in 1 Chronicles 6:26.

See Zuph (Person).

Zophar

Zophar was one of the "counselors" of Job, listed as a Naamathite (Job 2:11; 11:1; 20:1). He offers the most direct accusations against Job. But later, he offers a sacrifice to Yahweh, as the Lord had commanded (42:9).

Zophim

A place from which Balaam pronounced his second blessing upon Israel (Numbers 23:13–16). Zophim must have been on or near Mount Pisgah.

Zorah, Zorathite

A city of the Shephelah and its people, attributed to both the tribe of Dan and of Judah (Jos 15:33; 19:41). It was part of Judah's original allocation but was settled by Danites until they established their own territory near Laish (Jgs 18:1–11). Originally Zorah and nearby Eshtaol seem to have been settled by residents of Kiriath-jearim (1 Chr 2:53; 4:2). The city was the home of Manoah, the father of Samson (Jgs 13:2). Samson's ministry was focused in the region surrounding Zorah and Eshtaol, and he was ultimately buried there. Zorah is traditionally identified with Tell Sur'ah, which is strategically located at the entrance to a large valley leading toward the Mediterranean plain.

Zorites

The Zorites were descendants of Salma from the tribe of Judah (1 Chronicles 2:54). They may have formed half of the Manahathite family group.

Zorobabel

The King James Version form of Zerubbabel, Jerusalem's governor after the exile in Babylon, in Matthew 1:12–13 and Luke 3:27.

See Zerubbabel.

Zuar

The father of Nethanel. Nethanel was the leader of the tribe of Issachar when the Israelites began their journey through the wilderness after leaving Egypt (Numbers 1:8; 2:5; 7:18, 23; 10:15).

Zuph (Person)

Ancestor of Elkanah, the father of the prophet Samuel (1 Sm 1:1). Zuph was a member of the Kohathite branch of Levites and is listed as the son of Elkanah (different than above) and the father of Toah (1 Chr 6:35). He is the same as Zophai listed in 1 Chronicles 6:26. It is evident that Zuph was a Levite, even though he is listed as an Ephraimite in the 1 Samuel passage.

Zuph (Place)

Place where Saul looked for his father's donkeys prior to his meeting with Samuel (1 Sm 9:5). It was near the tomb of Rachel, which is traditionally placed near the northern border of Benjamin. Zuph is apparently linked with Samuel, as one of his ancestors bore the name (see 1 Sm 1:1; 1 Chr 6:35), and his native town was called Ramathaim-zophim.

Zur

1. A prince of Midian and the father of Cozbi, a Midianite woman who was killed by Phinehas. Cozbi was in an improper relationship with Zimri, an Israelite man, during the incident at Baal-peor (Numbers 25:15). Zur was later killed by the Israelites, along with four other Midianite kings and Balaam, as part of God's judgment on Midian (31:8). He seems to have been under the authority of Sihon, the Amorite king, since he is listed as one of "the princes of Sihon" in Joshua 13:21.
2. A son of Jeiel, who established the town of Gibeon (1 Chronicles 8:30; 9:36). He was from the tribe of Benjamin and was a distant relative of King Saul.

Zuriel

The son of Abihail and the head of the Merari family of Levites during the wilderness wanderings of Israel (Numbers 3:35).

Zurishaddai

The father of Shelumiel. Shelumiel was the leader of the tribe of Simeon when the Israelites began their journey through the wilderness after leaving Egypt (Numbers 1:6; 2:12; 7:36, 41; 10:19).

Zuzim, Zuzites

One of the kingdoms attacked and defeated by Kedorlaomer's confederation (Gn 14:5), mentioned as residents of Ham. They were likely located somewhere north of the Arnon River, since the general path of Kedorlaomer was from north to south along the King's Highway. Possibly these Zuzites are associated with the Zamzummites of Deuteronomy 2:20, since both are linked to the same geographical proximity. Furthermore, both passages speak of them in connection with races of giants, including the Horites, the Emim, and the Rephaim.